

▼ 'For e-mail on the go, a PDA is as good as a laptop'



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As a brand manager for up-market luxury brands, Savant often has to shuttle between his office in India and headquarters in Europe. He relies on his Nokia Communicator 9210i for daily communication. Here's what Savant had to say to us about his preference for a PDA-phone over a laptop.

"When you're travelling, the weight and size of the device really matters. Any laptop weighs over a kilogram, and the 250 grams of a PDA-phone is a significant reduction. Secondly, I

use the 9210i for scheduling my meetings, anniversary reminders, etc. when travelling; the PDA-phone notifies me about such events instantly—it's not this way with laptops for the simple reason that they aren't switched on all the time.

Practically speaking, a laptop is a better bet if you do lot of presentations, work with sheets, etc. But for e-mail on the go, a PDA is as good as a laptop. The added phone features make it even better—you can stay in touch with your loved ones."

considered pocket material, its large display is prone to scratches, and should not leave home without protection. Finally, the Communicator series from Nokia was not meant for the pocket, and the 9500 is no exception.

Next, we tested the usability of each device. Here's where the data input method, display properties, UI speed, applications and connectivity come to the fore, and make all the difference between a good product and a bad one.

Display Properties

We looked at and evaluated the screen size, screen resolution, screen orientation, legibility of text, and colour depth of the display used in these devices.

The Nokia 9500 is graced with a 65K colour display—long, crisp, and perfectly legible even with outdoor lighting. The screen is horizontally placed and is perfect for reading documents and browsing the Net. These same qualities can be attributed to the 7710's screen; however, the 7710 has the upper hand when it comes to the size and resolution of the screen.

The O2 XDA II mini comes with a 320 x 240, 65K colour screen, which is almost the same as the Nokia screens in terms of quality. With its ability to switch between the landscape and portrait modes, it has its own benefits to offer. The Blackberry's screen has sufficient resolution for messaging—its screen, though low on brightness,

offers excellent contrast, and is very legible under all lighting conditions. The Motorola A768i comes with a crisp 65K colour screen, but the screen is useless in daylight—it turns dark and is unreadable.

Data Input

Nokia's 9500 Communicator comes with a sufficiently spacious QWERTY keyboard that makes data entry a breeze. In general, the keyboard is fairly

ergonomic, but people with short fingers might have problems with key navigation—stretching for a key is a common scenario, which in time leads to fatigue.

Both the PalmOne Treo 600 and the Blackberry 7730 employ a small QWERTY keypad. The keys on the Blackberry are well-spaced and slightly slanted to avoid accidental presses, and data input is fuss-free. The keys on the Treo 600 are tiny, but are raised like a dome; these take some time to get used to. A point to remember with the Treo 600 is that although it is based on the Palm OS, it does not support data input via the stylus; you can only use the stylus for navigation.

The 7710 is the first production device from Nokia with a touch screen, employing a stylus for data input. Data input is where, however, the 7710 could have done better. While its letter recognition is highly accurate, the 7710 can only take one character at a time. Furthermore, the scribble area is too small for comfort. It

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BlackBerry 7730

does come with an onscreen keyboard though.

Motorola's A768i also makes use of a stylus; however, its character recognition and speed is nowhere near the likes of the O2 XDA II mini or the Nokia 7710.

Thanks largely to Microsoft's Pocket PC OS, data input via a stylus on the O2 XDA II mini is fantastic. Character recognition is excellent—so much so that you can input data much faster than you can with the keyboard-based 9500 Communicator!

For any handheld device, one-handed operation is a must; the PalmOne Treo 600 and the Blackberry 7730 were the only devices to offer complete one-handed operation. The Nokia 7710, the O2 XDA II mini, and the Motorola A768i meet you halfway on this facet, while the Nokia Communicator 9500 requires you to use both your hands for data input or for accessing information.

User Interface Speed

The answer to how fast applications open largely determines the usability of a device. This apparent speed depends on the processor performance as well as the OS.

The O2 XDA II mini was the zippiest of all, thanks to its 416 MHz XScale processor and Microsoft's Pocket PC OS. The PalmOne Treo 600 took second place, while the Blackberry was sufficiently responsive. Tasks involving larger files, though, slowed down the device. Both the Nokia 7710 and the 9500 were the least responsive of the lot. The snail's pace at which they launch your applications wrecks your nerves. Having noted that, it has to be said that these devices exhibit sluggishness only

during the launching of applications; once the application is launched, the devices resume acceptable speeds.

Messaging

If your life revolves around e-mail, the Blackberry should be your first stop. It makes your e-mail system as fast as an SMS service—immediately following the receipt of a mail, you get a system notification, thus eliminating the



PalmOne Treo 600